

The year when smart assistants mature

Cellphone and tablet designs have sort of reached an apex point and going forward we are not going to see a drastic change in design (except maybe if we see bendable/foldable displays). The updated devices may otherwise have more iterative changes or more power-optimised innards. The differentiating factor for smart devices will not be the hardware itself, operating systems may be to an extent, but the major deal-breaker will be services offered on the platform. This year, I believe there will be a fierce battle between personal assistant services. Siri and Google Now (+ Google Voice Search) for now, but who knows which other disruption might happen in this space this year.

Siri, the voice assistant from Apple, was launched along with the iPhone 4S and has had its run for quite a while. It is still in the beta stage though, as it continues to be rolled out in different languages. Flawless speech recognition is still a tough nut to crack, and Siri definitely struggles with Indian accents. Recognising speech is just one part, what follows is processing the speech, putting it in context and giving you the results. It's a novelty factor, which is sure to dip. But Siri understands context better, whereas with Google's Voice Search you will need to frame questions in a particular way to get the response.

Google Now came out in the second half of 2012, and is present only on those handsets and tablets which have Android version 4.1 and up. That is a miniscule number when compared to Apple's Siri users. So one may think the advantage is with Siri. Well so far, in terms of numbers, yes.

When you look at how technologies have evolved over the years, we have always moved from pull to push. That is one major differentiating factor between Siri and Google Now. Siri is pull (you need to ask it a question to get a response) and Google Now is push (cards are pulled without you actively asking for them). There itself, Google has an edge.

Google Now takes into consideration your location, your search habits, your calendar, weather, time of the day and so on to deliver relevant information cards to you. You can get the cards even with Google's voice search, but that is no fun; getting a card telling you the quickest route to your home as you are leaving office, or a card telling you which movie is showing on your way home in your favourite theatre with road directions, is.

As phones get smarter and more powerful, the importance of smart assistants will increase. Siri or Google Now's success will depend in a large part on how they tackle this demand. No one wants to download a gazillion apps for his or her needs. If a smart assistant can do all the work that stand-alone apps can do, then it bypasses active human interaction thereby saving time. More apps = more distraction. Google Now has an advantage in that regard thanks to its Google backend which will allow Google Now to pull in data from Google apps such as Gmail, Maps, Zagat, YouTube and so on. Siri uses Wolfram Alpha for search related queries. Wolfram Alpha as well all know, is no match to Google's search servers when it comes to pop-culture, location-awareness or crowdsourcing. Looking at the way Google Now has increased the number of cards, there will be many more relevant cards added.

Consider a scenario where smart assistants are able to communicate with internet-enabled devices. The Internet of things, a blanket term for connected objects talking to each other over a common network, is the future. Think of a sensor on your body relaying your pulse rate information to your smart assistant, which then decides to send across a mail to your general physician or making a call to the doctor, in case of an emergency. Maybe your smart fridge will send a message to your smart assistant, and you are informed about milk running low at home. Nowhere are you actively checking for anything. With Google Glass expected to come out in the near future, you will have all your cards delivered to you without you even having to remove your phone from your pocket. The possibilities are endless.

Of course, these smart assistants will also raise a lot of questions about privacy but if you want to enjoy these benefits, you will have to compromise on that. No matter what you do, unless you are off the internet, there is a significant amount of your life that is already known by players such as Google, Apple or Facebook. So it's naive to think that these smart assistants will do more harm than good. You can always opt out.

One thing is inevitable: the real stars in keynote addresses will be these smart assistants and their development, as there is only so much you can improve upon hardware design. Maybe we can have something close to Jarvis (Iron Man's personal assistant)? Who knows? 



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